

Why do landlords want a lump sum instead of monthly rent?

「 집주인은 왜 월세 대신 목돈을 원할까 」

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Photo: Ricardo Gomez Angel · Unsplash

친구가 "전세로 구해봐"라고 했는데, 집주인이 월세 없이 1억 원을 통째로 맡기라고 하면 당황스러워요.

My friend told me to "look for a jeonse place," but it's confusing when the landlord asks you to hand over the full 100 million won with no monthly rent at all.

월세도 안 받는데 집주인은 대체 뭘로 돈을 버는 걸까요?

If they're not even collecting monthly rent, how on earth does the landlord make money?

이 궁금증에는 진짜 경제학이 숨어 있어요.

Real economics is hiding behind this question.

집주인은 이 돈으로 뭘 할까

What does the landlord do with this money

전세는 집주인이 세입자 돈을 몇 년간 빌려 쓰는 거예요.

Jeonse is basically the landlord borrowing the tenant's money for a few years.

예전엔 은행 이자가 높아서, 집주인이 그 목돈을 은행에만 넣어둬도 월세보다 많이 벌었어요.

Back in the day, bank interest rates were high, so landlords could earn more than they would from monthly rent just by parking that lump sum in the bank.

지금은 이자가 낮아졌지만, 대신 집주인들은 그 돈으로 집 살 때 빌린 대출을 갚아요.

Interest rates have gone down now, but instead, landlords use that money to pay off the loan they took out to buy the house.

대출 이자를 줄이는 게 곧 돈을 버는 셈이라, 세입자에게 매달 월세를 받을 필요가 없어진 거예요.

Cutting the loan interest is basically the same as earning money, so they no longer need to collect monthly rent from tenants.

나가기 전에 확인할 것

Things to check before moving out

- 전세인지 반전세인지 먼저 물어보기: 반전세는 목돈에 월세를 조금 더 내는 방식이라 계산이 달라져요.

- Ask first whether it's jeonse or ban-jeonse: ban-jeonse involves paying a lump sum plus a bit of monthly rent, so the calculation is different.

- 집이 대출을 얼마나 안고 있는지 등기부등본으로 보기: 대출이 너무 많으면 집주인이 돈을 못 돌려줄 위험이 커요.

- Check the property registration document to see how much debt the house carries: if the loan is too large, there's a higher risk the landlord won't be able to return your deposit.

- 전세보증보험 가입 가능 여부 확인하기: HUG(주택도시보증공사) 홈페이지에서 이 집이 보험 대상인지 미리 확인할 수 있어요.

- Check whether jeonse deposit guarantee insurance is available: you can check in advance on the HUG (Korea Housing & Urban Guarantee Corporation) website whether this property is eligible for insurance.

목돈이 크게 느껴져도, 집주인이 그 돈으로 뭘 하는지 알면 전세가 왜 이렇게 굴러가는지 이해가 될 거예요.

Even if the lump sum feels huge, once you understand what the landlord does with that money, you'll get why jeonse works the way it does.

Words & Phrases

1 전세 *jeonse* **NOUN**

lump-sum deposit lease

Jeonse is a distinctively Korean rental system where the tenant pays one large deposit instead of monthly rent, and gets it back in full when the lease ends. It's the central concept of the whole post, and its counterpart with reduced deposit plus small monthly rent is called 반전세 (banjeonse).

전세는 집주인이 세입자 돈을 몇 년간 빌려 쓰는 거예요.

2 목돈 *mokdon* **NOUN**

lump sum of money

목돈 refers to a large sum of money saved or handled at once, as opposed to small amounts paid regularly (like 월세, monthly rent). It's a common everyday noun used whenever big one-time sums of cash are discussed, e.g. for a deposit, a house, or a wedding.

예전엔 은행 이자가 높아서, 집주인이 그 목돈을 은행에만 넣어둬도 월세보다 많이 벌었어요.

3 반전세 *banjeonse* **NOUN**

semi-jeonse (deposit + partial rent)

반전세 is a hybrid rental arrangement between full 전세 (deposit only) and 월세 (monthly rent only): the tenant pays a smaller deposit than a normal jeonse plus a reduced monthly rent. Learners should know this term to compare housing contract types in Korea.

반전세는 목돈에 월세를 조금 더 내는 방식이라 계산이 달라져요.

4 등기부등본 *deunggibudeungbon* **NOUN**

property registry certificate

This is the official government document that records ownership and any loans/liens attached to a piece of real estate; renters in Korea check it to see how much debt is on a property before signing a lease. It's a fairly technical/bureaucratic noun, often paired with the verb '떼다' (to issue/obtain a copy of it).

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5 굴러가다 *gulleogada* **VERB**

to run/operate (a system)

Literally meaning 'to roll along,' 굴러가다 is used idiomatically here to describe how a system, process, or arrangement functions or keeps working. It's informal/conversational, similar in feel to English 'how it all works' or 'how things keep turning.'

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www.durukorean.com/blog/post/jeonse-lump-sum-deposit-explained

